

## Part III — The Veil

### WHY THIS PART — WHAT IS HAPPENING AND WHY

The Step-Daughter names the drama they carry — a moment, she promises, when *we lose this little darling* — and the Mother breaks under it: the faint, the chair, and the veil the Father lifts against her will. Wife and widow at once; the lover dead two months; a son who is his, children who are not. *She isn't a woman, she is a mother.*

Then the money enters the room: a hundred francs in a pale blue envelope on a little mahogany table, in the back room of a dressmaker's shop — a transaction this town has agreed not to talk about, and “a near thing, though.” The Step-Daughter claims the shame and the revenge in one breath. The room stops being entertained and begins to be implicated; the amber light tightens on the family.

### THE SCRIPT, LINE BY LINE — WITH WHAT EACH LINE IS DOING

*She seizes the plot's wheel entirely, mapping every turn in advance to leave the Father no corner of the story he can claim.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[to Manager]*. Worse? Listen! Stage this drama now, sir! At a certain moment, when we lose this little darling, and this fool here *[Seizing the coat off the chair and shaking it.]* does the stupidest thing — you will see me run away. But the moment hasn't come yet. After what has taken place between him and me *[Indicating the Father with a horrible wink.]*, I can't stay here, watching her anguish over that fool *[Indicates the Son.]*. Look at him — frigid, indifferent, because he is the *legitimate* son. He despises us all because we are bastards. *[Goes to the Mother and embraces her.]* And he won't even recognise her as his mother. *Wretch.*

*Her body speaks before language can: the arms pulling both children close, then falling, say what no sentence of hers has managed.*

**THE MOTHER** *[to the Manager; one arm tightens around the Child-bundle, the other goes toward the Boy-chair as if to keep both of them upright]*. In the name of these two little children, I beg you... *[She grows faint and is about to fall.]* Oh God!

*Chivalry deployed as staging — he rushes forward to help and, in the same motion, casts himself as the scene's moral anchor.*

**THE FATHER** *[coming forward to support her as do some of the Actors]*. Quick, a chair, a chair for this poor widow!

*Unable to distinguish grief from theatre, the Actors reach for the only category they know and ask whether the collapse is real.*

**PLAYER 1, PLAYER 2 & PLAYER 3**. Is it true? Has she really fainted?

*He calls for the chair and is already directing — the practical crisis and the scene he wants to shape are, for him, the same thing.*

**THE MANAGER**. Quick, a chair! Here! *[One of the Actors brings a chair, the Others proffer assistance. The Mother tries to prevent the Father from lifting the veil which covers her face.]*

*Forcing the Mother's face into public view, he turns her pain into an exhibit that proves his own suffering.*

**THE FATHER**. Look at her! Look at her!

*Her 'no' is not modesty; the veil is the last membrane between a private wound and the spectacle the Father is building around her.*

**THE MOTHER**. No, no; stop it please!

*Lifting the veil, he borrows her body as evidence — the same appropriation that defined the marriage he is now narrating.*

**THE FATHER** *[raising her veil]*. Let them see you!

*Turning to the Manager, she names for the first time exactly what she cannot bear: being made into testimony in someone else's argument.*

**THE MOTHER** *[rising and covering her face with her hands]*. I beg you, sir. Stop him. I cannot bear what he wants to do.

*Reaching for the tidiest domestic category he knows, the Manager hopes 'wife' or 'widow' will restore the authority this family is stripping from him.*

**THE MANAGER** *[dumbfounded]*. I don't understand at all. Is this lady your wife? *[To the **Father**.]*

*Flat confirmation coated in possessive pride — he claims her still, without noticing that the claim convicts him.*

**THE FATHER**. Yes, gentlemen: my wife!

*The laugh is a defence: the Actors grab the logical absurdity to avoid looking at the emotional reality it floats on top of.*

**THE MANAGER**. But how can she be a widow if you are alive? *[The Actors find relief for their astonishment in a loud laugh.]*

*He needs the room solemn because laughter dissolves the gravity in which his reframing of events can take hold.*

**THE FATHER**. Don't laugh! Don't laugh like that, for Heaven's sake. Her drama lies just here in this: she has had a lover, a man who should be here.

*The cry escapes before she can catch it; the hand at her mouth shows the years of practice she has had doing exactly that.*

**THE MOTHER** *[the cry surprising her — a hand goes to her own mouth, as if to catch it]*. No! No!

*Mourning etiquette deployed as irony — 'most respectable' strips the black clothes of every comfort they were meant to provide.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. Fortunately for her, sir, he is dead. Two months ago, as I said. We are in mourning, as you see. Most respectable.

*Reclassifying the Mother as a function rather than a person, he erases her desire so that only his philosophical architecture remains standing.*

**THE FATHER**. He isn't here — but not because he is dead. He isn't here because her drama is not a drama of love at all. She felt nothing for either of us — perhaps a little gratitude, not for me, for the other. She isn't a woman, she is a mother. And her drama, sir, lies all in these four children she has had by two men.

*At the word children, the **Mother's** arm closes around the Child-bundle, before any word comes.*

*Breaking her habitual silence, she shifts the grammar from passive to active — 'he gave me' — and for the first time holds the story in her own hands.*

**THE MOTHER**. I had them? Have you got the courage to say that I *wanted* them? *[To the **Company**.]* It was him. He gave me to that other man. He made me go.

*A reflex of loyalty more than an argument; she is fighting a different battle from the Mother and does not notice the difference.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. It isn't true.

*Two challenges in one breath — the denial and the deeper wound: what can the daughter know of what the mother was made to do?*

**THE MOTHER** *[her hand tightens on the Child-bundle without her noticing]*. Not true? And what can you know about it?

*Her defence of the Father is also self-defence — absolving him keeps the Son's indifference inexcusable and the family wound permanently open.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. It isn't true. Don't believe it. *[To **Manager**.]* Do you know why she says so? For that fellow there. *[Indicates the **Son**.]* She tortures herself, destroys herself on account of the neglect of that son there; and she wants him to believe that if she abandoned him when he was only two years old, it was because this man *[Indicates the **Father**.]* forced her to it.

One glance upward toward the Son who does not return it, one immediate retreat: the whole arc of maternal failure compressed into a stage direction.

**THE MOTHER** [voice tight; eyes still on the floor]. He forced me to it. [Silence. No one fills it. For the first time she raises her eyes — to the **Son**. He does not look back. She lowers them again.] And I call God to witness it. [To the **Manager**, still without lifting her head.] Ask him [Indicates the **Father**.] if it isn't true. Let him speak. You [To the **Step-Daughter**.] are not in a position to know anything about it.

The dead father's tenderness is wielded as a weapon; happiness in that house becomes evidence against the Mother's claim of coercion.

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. I know you lived in peace and happiness with my father while he lived. Can you deny it?

Unable to lie about the happiness, she concedes complexity — and the honesty costs her the argument before she can finish the sentence.

**THE MOTHER**. No, I don't deny it...

Shaking the empty coat as if the dead man could still testify, she lets grief show through the violence of the gesture.

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. He was always full of affection and kindness for you. [Turning on the Boy-chair, gripping the lapel of the coat as if shaking him by it.] It's true, isn't it? Tell them! Why don't you speak, you little fool?

Still loyal to the dead man's memory, she draws a careful line between the act of leaving and any passion that might have excused it.

**THE MOTHER**. Leave him alone. Why do you want to make me appear ungrateful, daughter? I don't want to offend your father. I have told him: I did not leave my house and my son through any fault of mine. Not from any wilful passion.

Three words stripped of all philosophical scaffolding — the Father's brevity here is more damning than any speech he has delivered.

**THE FATHER**. It's true. It was my doing.

His sentence dies when his eyes reach the Mother; real pain crosses into the theatre space and the appetite for spectacle curdles into something else.

**PLAYER 1** [to the **Company**, beginning to relish it — then his eyes reach the **Mother**, and the end of the sentence does not arrive]. What a spectacle. What an absolute... [He stops. The treat has gone out of it.]

Quietly, without irony, she marks the inversion: the professionals have been demoted and the family they cannot perform for has become the show.

**PLAYER 2** [lower now]. We are the audience this time.

One phrase landing in silence does what a full sentence could not — the absence of laughter proves the normal social release has been shut down.

**PLAYER 3** [quietly, the pencil not moving]. For once. [Nobody laughs.]

Leaning forward the way an audience member does when they have stopped pretending not to care, the sceptic is becoming a witness against his will.

**THE MANAGER** [beginning to get really interested — leaning slightly forward, the way an audience member does when they have started to listen]. Let's hear them out. Listen!

Pre-emptive ridicule is the Son's only weapon: label the philosophy fast enough and perhaps it will not seduce the room before he can stop it.

**THE SON**. Oh yes, you're going to hear a fine bit now. He will talk to you of the Demon of Experiment.

Buried inside the attack is the most honest thing he says — 'the phrase I've found to excuse myself with' — and he covers it immediately with more argument.

**THE FATHER**. You are a cynical imbecile. [To the **Manager**.] He mocks me for the phrase I've found to excuse myself with.

Monotone repetition performs the very thing it accuses; he too uses a word as a wall to keep the Father's reality at arm's length.

**THE SON** [without looking up]. Yes. Phrases. Phrases.

*Universalising his failure into everyone's condition, he redistributes guilt until no single person can be held to account for anything specific.*

**THE FATHER.** Phrases! And isn't everyone consoled by a word — some simple word that means nothing, and yet calms us?

*She turns his own defence of comforting words into the indictment: words are the cheap thing — and then names what he was ready to spend instead.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Words cost nothing. *[A second's pause — she lets it sit.]* He was prepared to pay.

*Two words and he is already reaching to stop her; the interruption fails, and failing is the point.*

**THE FATHER.** Must you—

*Making the abstraction sordid and exact, she times the detail of the money to destroy whatever sympathy the Father has carefully built.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Yes, there was money. A nice little bit. The hundred francs he was about to lay down for me, gentlemen — and I two months an orphan. *[A ripple of unease among the Actors.]*

*His disgust at her exposure mirrors his own refusal to confront the family's wound; what he calls vile, he also calls too close to home.*

**THE SON** *[to the Step-Daughter]*. This is vile.

*With forensic precision she catalogues the shop, forcing the polite euphemism 'robes et manteaux' to carry its real cargo of exploitation and exchange.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Vile? There they were in a pale blue envelope on a little mahogany table in the back of Madame Pace's shop. You know Madame Pace, sir — one of those *ladies* who take in poor girls of good family on the pretext of selling *robes et manteaux*. The pretext is always *robes*. The arrangement is always something else.

*As the shop is named, the Mother draws the Child-bundle up against her and covers its ears with her hand.*

*The unpaid money becomes a moral paradox: the Father is guilty of the intention even though the act was interrupted, desire proven by the attempt.*

**THE SON.** And he thinks he bought the right to tyrannize over us with that hundred francs. Which — note this, gentlemen — he never got the chance to pay.

*Compressed into one ironic laugh: bitterness, survivor relief, and self-contempt — a sound that has nowhere respectable to land.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** It was a near thing, though, you know! *[the laugh she means to be ironic does not quite come]*

*She turns the Child's face away before she speaks; the words are addressed inward, a reflex to shield innocence from shame already filling the room.*

**THE MOTHER** *[low, not raised; she turns the Child-bundle's face into her shoulder before she speaks — the words are for the bundle, not the room]*. Shame, my daughter. *[A breath. The Step-Daughter's laugh is still in the air.]* Not in front of her.

*Claiming ownership of the shame and inverting it into power, she reconstructs the room so exactly that memory becomes re-enactment and the Father cannot intervene.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Shame? Oh, the shame is mine — and the *revenge*. I am dying to live that scene. The room — I see it. Here is the window with the mantles in display, there the divan, a screen, and in front of the window the little mahogany table with the blue envelope and its hundred francs. I can almost take hold of it. But you, gentlemen, might look elsewhere for this part of it. I do not blush, however. *He* does. *[Indicating Father.]*

*Pirandello plants the Manager here as a surrogate for the audience — confusion on stage to licence confusion in the house.*

**THE MANAGER** *[the audience's confusion, on stage]*. I don't understand this at all.